

The term “meme” was introduced by the biologist Richard Dawkins in his 1976 book *The Selfish Gene*. As part of his larger effort to apply evolutionary theory to cultural change, Dawkins defined memes as small cultural units of transmission, analogous to genes, that spread from person to person by copying or imitation. Examples of memes in his pioneering essay include cultural artifacts such as melodies, catchphrases, and clothing fashions, as well as abstract beliefs (for instance, the concept of God). Like genes, memes are defined as replicators that undergo variation, competition, selection, and retention. At any given moment, many memes are competing for the attention of hosts; however, only memes suited to their sociocultural environment spread successfully, while others become extinct. Dawkins also noted that certain groups of coadaptive memes tend to be replicated together—strengthening each other in the process. Dawkins called such groups “coadapted meme complexes,” a tag later shortened by Hans-Cees Speel to “memeplexes.”¹ Democracy, for instance, can be regarded as a memeplex that includes several submemeplexes such as human rights and free regular elections, which can further be broken down to respective memes.

The word “meme” derives from the Greek *mimema*, signifying “something which is imitated,” which Dawkins shortened to rhyme with “gene.” Interestingly, a similar term to signify cultural evolution had appeared a century earlier. In 1870 the Austrian sociologist Ewald Hering coined the term “die Mneme” (from the Greek *mneme*, meaning memory), which the German biologist Richard Semon used in the title of a book he published in 1904. Unaware of this existing terminology, Dawkins’s expression proved an accidental but successful imitation in itself: his concept survived and proliferated in the scientific world.

After more than a decade of sporadic growth, memetics—described by Francis Heylighen and Klaas Chielens³ as “the theoretical and empirical science that studies the replication, spread and evolution of memes”—began to take shape as an active research program, drawing scientists from many fields in the 1990s. Important landmarks on this path included contributions from the prominent philosophers Douglas Hofstadter and Daniel C. Dennett, the emergence of the *Journal of Memetics* in 1997 and its publication until 2005, and the publication of several A telegrAphic BIogrAphy of A conceptuAl trouBleMAker 11 meme-oriented books. Of these, Susan Blackmore’s *The Meme Machine* from 1999 may well be the most influential, yet also the most disputed.